

Money Mistake: You Don't Talk to Your Kids about Money

THE FIX: TEACH THEM VALUE FIRST

Babies eat and sleep, toddlers destroy everything, and kids like to spend like there's no tomorrow. And lest you think I was always a bossy bald guy, I, too, was a kid who liked things, who wanted the latest everything and would go to any length to get it.

I couldn't have been more than five years old when I first coveted something I didn't quite have enough to buy. For weeks I even visited it at the store. It was an airplane made of balsa wood, with a wind-up plastic propeller. The package said it actually flew. But it cost two dollars. For a month, I saved up money from a 50-cent-a-week allowance my mother gave my brother, Shane, and me. My grandmother was visiting us that afternoon and I proudly showed her my purchase. She took a hard look at the airplane, the way an archaeologist would scrutinize a weird relic. After a minute, she handed it back to me as if it was covered in cooties.

"Why, Kevin?" she asked.

"Why what?"

"Why did you spend two dollars on this?"

"Because I like it. I wanted it."

"But look at it, Kevin." It was as if she was pleading with me. "It's junk. It's made of nothing but scraps. It's going to fall apart after your first day playing with it."

She gave me that piercing, stern look again, making me reconsider my answer. Finally, I said, "I don't know why I bought it."

I will never forget that moment. My joy turned instantly into shame. For the first time, I actually scrutinized what I had bought—I mean, *really* looked at it. The toy (every toy) holds potent promises for kids: fun, fitting in, and friendship. That's a heady combination. That's why every commercial for a game or a toy will show kids with their friends, and the cover art of every box includes a tacit promise of fitting in with a peer group. And kids just want to fit in and be liked. Kids also want to be envied. (Having been one myself, I know a child's